

The First 48 Hours of a Recall

A reverse-logistics checklist for the physical product, what to secure, segregate, and document before the returns start moving.

Most recall checklists cover notifications and press. This one covers the part that actually creates liability: the physical inventory. Work it in order, the first two days decide whether a recall stays contained or becomes a diversion problem.

PHASE 1 - HOURS 0-6

Stop The Bleeding

- ☐ Freeze outbound shipment of the affected lot(s) across every DC and 3PL at once, one instruction, everywhere, immediately.
- ☐ Locate every place the product sits: your DCs, contract warehouses, in-transit loads, distributor and retailer stock, and returns already moving.
- ☐ Pull the lot / batch / SKU list from the recall notice and map it to inventory records. Know exactly what is affected and how much.
- ☐ Assign one owner for physical disposition. Recalls unravel when five people each assume someone else has the inventory.
- ☐ Secure, don't discard. Do not destroy or move anything beyond securing it. Premature disposal without documentation is a problem, not progress.

PHASE 2 - HOURS 6-24

Contain & Quarantine

- ☐ Physically segregate recalled stock from sellable inventory, separate, labeled, access-controlled space. Co-mingled product is a re-shipment waiting to happen.
- ☐ Start chain of custody now: log who holds the product, where, and every movement from this point forward. You will have to reconcile it later.
- ☐ Confirm whether your warehousing is actually certified to hold quarantined recalled product under chain of custody. Most standard 3PL space is not.
- ☐ Count quantities at each location and reconcile against the recall scope. Flag the gaps, product already sold, in transit, or unaccounted for.
- ☐ Preserve records: lot documentation, shipment history, storage conditions, and photographs of the segregated stock.

Decide the reverse path

- ☐ Set the disposition for each portion: return, quarantine-and-hold, certified destruction, or rework / relabel. Different product, different answer.
- ☐ For destruction: confirm the method fits the product and that you'll receive an itemized certificate of destruction, quantity, lot numbers, witness, manifests, not a courtesy letter.
- ☐ For rework / relabel: confirm the operator can bring product back into spec and document it, so saved product is provably compliant.
- ☐ Match capacity to the deadline: does the receiving facility have real space and the right certification available on your timeline, not a website that claims it?
- ☐ Line up the documentation flow now, manifests, weight tickets, certificates, retained on your recall clock, not filed and forgotten.

FIVE PRINCIPLES THAT KEEP A RECALL CONTAINED

- Disposal ends possession; certified destruction ends liability.
- Segregate before you decide, never co-mingle recalled and sellable stock.
- Reconcile: what was pulled must equal what was disposed.
- The clock is the regulator's, not yours.
- Standard warehouse space is not certified quarantine space.

WHEN YOU HIT THE PART THIS CHECKLIST CAN'T DO FOR YOU

Knowing the steps is the easy part. Finding a facility certified to quarantine, destroy, or rework your product, with real capacity this week, while the clock runs, is the hard part.

That's what we do.

Book a 20-minute call → zeropsgroup.com

